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Book of Job—Divine Speeches Assignment

4/30/19

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The ‘Divine Speeches’ in the “Book of Job” are the culmination of the dialectic between Job’s complaints and his friend’s theodicies. Ostensibly, the interpretation of the Divine Speeches is the keystone which unlocks how one reads the preceding dialectic. One key passage in Job 42 is when Job states, “Surely I spoke of things I did not understand,/ things too wonderful for me to know.” This passage has often been interpreted as saying that, after the encounter with God in the whirlwind, Job has been put in his place and realizes the superior structure of providence which contextualizes his suffering. Nevertheless—it remains to be asked: what is it that Job saw that allowed him to understand his suffering more deeply? In this essay, it will be argued that what Job saw, and hence what the meaning of the divine speeches are, is that there is no God and hence no cosmic author to suffering—hence Job’s refusal to accept any of his friend’s theodicies is vindicated because there is no cosmic justice to which his acts are accountable and for which his suffering was justified. Instead, there is merely the internal power of reason to continue to ask, “why” which is the rebellious act implicit in all complaints. To support this reading, I will invoke the following interpretations of Job to understand the divine speeches: Antonio Negri’s “The Labor of Job”, Ernst Bloch’s “Atheism in Christianity”, and Immanuel Kant’s “The Miscarriage of All Trials in Theodicy”.

Antonio Negri’s “The Labor of Job” was written during his prison sentence where he was accused of having participated in far-left terrorist organizations. In this text, he argues that the

book of Job is a text about the incommensurability of human labor and how every attempt to produce equivalences between different forms of human labor produce an unjust calculation which exploits the suffering of the proletariat for the sake of societal reproduction. Hence, while Job's friends are taken to be the forerunners of bourgeois economic theory, accounting for the economy of suffering through a series of justified equivalence, it is Job who stands his ground and states that there can be no fair recompense for the suffering he has undergone.

Negri relates theodicy to the question of justice and equivalence—namely, for the just remuneration of labor's suffering. In standard Marxist theory, the belief is that the proletariat are not given their full earnings—instead, wages subtract some fraction of the total productivity of labor to produce what is called surplus-value, or profit. After recounting Job 21:30-34, Negri states, "Value, labor, and justice cannot be apportioned according to a common measure" (36) and hence recognizing that the distinction Marx draws between use-value and exchange-value isn't meant to illustrate two orders of accounting for value, but how the distinction itself is produced to mystify the incommensurability between the two forms—that is, that there is no proper remuneration for an hour of one's life other than its own fruit. Hence the retributive structure of "just exchange" is precisely what Negri recognizes Job as protesting against when his friends say that his circumstances must be the fruit of some sin either hidden or visible—he even states that the belief in the possibility of just remuneration was the failure of the Soviet system and claims, "Socialism is the apologia for a retributive theory of justice, human action, and social rewards. In contrast, Job in his first bored and sarcastic reply has already moved beyond Stakhanov" (36). Instead, the horizon of Job's complaint is thoroughly eschatological.

Such eschatological thinking is the ground for genuine Marxism, as well, according to Negri, as he states, "The problem of salvation is all the more important for those who have been

Marxists” (9). It is not the case that labor is legitimated through the exchange of its just remuneration. Theodicy therefore is not only the legitimization of suffering in this world, under an omnipotent God, but also an economic task of legitimating the suffering of labor through a notion of measure or equivalence which justifies the pain of labor. For Negri this is because this would reduce human activity to merely a reproduction of the status quo: “Divine justice exists as a dialectical theodicy. In the words of Eliphaz: God is zealous in the use of evil for the reconstruction of good” (32). But there can be no common measure between evil and good since such a ground would disqualify the very distinction. Quoting Ernst Bloch’s reading of the Book of Job which argues that it is a text which shows us “an exodus from the particular *status quo*” he states, instead, that Job demonstrates “the rupture of the horizon of axiological insignificance and vital indifference that is able to reconstitute a world of values” hence calling to attention how the divine speech at the end of the Book of Job not only frustrates human considerations, but shows us a world outside of any humanly instrumental schema. It is this vision of the world as open contingency as we see in Job 38:5—“Who determined its measurements—surely you know!/ Or who stretched the line upon it?” and Job 38:25—“Who has cut a channel for the torrents of rain,/ and a way for the thunderbolt,/ to bring rain on a land where no one lives”. Unable to be captured by the standards of human indexability and common measure, creation stands as a testament to the incalculable horizon outside of human reason—but reason can only approach such a horizon through the midst of its own suffering and hence Negri concludes, “The product of labor is no longer simply surplus labor and surplus value but the collective creation of a new world” (14).

Such a new creation is what constitutes ethics. Negri believes that this anticipation for the new world emerging in our suffering needs a new apology. By linking suffering, labor, and creation together, Negri is able to read the end of Job as not merely a reproduction of the status

quo but a redemption which creates a new society. Negri states, “God speaks here to the first man, to the Adam-Job who is himself formed by this monstrous process” (95). This link between Adam and Job, as Negri points out, will be a theme that the apostle Paul later picks up on in his own commentary on the book of Job. As Negri explains, “The Messiah who is realized here transforms the order of creation [...] he destroys, that is, recreates the measure of the world upon this rhythm. The Messiah is the second nature: a machine that produces and accumulates energy and applies it to *materia prima* so as to transform it” (102). Hence, Job is not merely a text about religious piety in the face of incomprehensible suffering but a promise that the labor of the proletariat will not be in vain but is in the process of birthing a world beyond Capital, a hope rooted in the messianic tradition that emerges in the rebellion of Job.

Another author who picks up on the link between Job’s suffering, messianism, and materialism is Ernst Bloch in “Atheism in Christianity”. Bloch is associated with the Frankfurt School of Marxism whose question, fundamentally, is how to continue to believe in instrumental reason when it has produced Auschwitz. Hence Bloch looks to the materialism inherent in the Bible, including the book of Job, as the ground on which we can continue to hope in reason’s culmination in a better society. Bloch argues from redaction scholarship to argue that the Bible actually contains two traditions—one exoteric tradition which preserves traditional piety, but also a secondary esoteric tradition of materialist resisters to the authoritarian Yahweh. This tradition begins with the snake in the garden of Eden (for Bloch, a promethean figure) and culminates in the messiah which, for Bloch, is the son of Man more than the son of God. Between these two members, however, is a third member—namely Job. He states of him: “He suffers indescribably and accuses Yahweh for it. That is, he no longer seeks the fault of his misfortune in his own weakness or guilt [...] His dreams rise out beyond himself to a different

life, a better way than the one he sees” (92). Job represents, therefore, the utopian horizon of hope as such—no longer contented with the traditional explanations of cause and effect, he makes a stand to inquire into the nature of things.

But when Job questions God, Bloch notices that God responds in a curious way: “And Yahweh replies... in a very strange way—with more questions and still more questions, interspersed with wild descriptions, of the peacock, the horse and the eagle, the storm... Behemoth and Leviathan” (96). This strange non-sequitur, which addresses Job’s accusations with propositions beyond the scope of Job’s conceivability, require an explanation. Not only that—but God replies with Job’s sarcasm (itself a subversion of the Psalmic discourse) with more sarcasm. On top of this, Bloch reminds us that Yahweh’s answer begins with Psalmic language but addressed to God’s-self: “When the morning stars sang to me together, and all the sons of God shouted for joy...” (97).

“As Bloch points out, “... the connection is unfair. Yahweh is replying to moral questions with physical ones...” which suggests a strange contradiction with the development of God throughout the rest of the Hebrew Bible (97). Bloch points out, “Yahweh’s works have ceased to be anthropocentric; human teleology breaks down [...] The stars, in contrast with Genesis 1.10 and 14, now precede the creation of the earth” (97). In other words, what we see in Job are implicit subversions of the tropes established in the canon thus far. Bloch reads these perversions of the character of God as evidence for his esoteric reading of the text. Earlier in the text, Bloch differentiates Yahweh’s persona with the pagan Gods when he states the following: ““Zeus is there as the punisher of all who bear themselves too loud and noisily, and his judgment is harsh” [...] How strange when compared with this is the idea of a God who is coming: a God who is a sea of righteousness, as Isaiah says in highly un-Present, Utopian way” (81). However,

at this stage in Job, Bloch identifies the divine discourse as belonging not to the previous Yahweh, but to another God who only shares Yahweh's identity nominally.

This authoritarian God, who puts arbitrary natural ends above nature, for Bloch, does not represent the tradition previously explained. Instead, he states that “[t]he whole theophany is so alien to the Bible that it is almost as if another God was there: one who has nothing in common even with the perilous Yahweh of the volcano” but instead suggests something more akin to a “demonic Isis or of a simple nature-Baal” or, “of another God some two thousand years later: Spinoza’s” noting that “the anti-teleological bias is a remarkable point of contact between them” (98). It is this picture of the world as cosmic indifference which Job rebels against throughout the text—either through the indifference of his friends who attempt to explain away Job’s suffering, or the indifference of an imposter-Yahweh who cannot even attempt to offer an explanation. From here, Bloch turns to the question of Job’s conversion.

It may seem that the end of Job where he “repents in dust and ashes” serves as a traditional reconciliation between the tried believer and the trying God—however, while such a reading would make sense for an anthropocentric God, the God of the book of Job has revealed itself to be a God indifferent to the concerns of humanity. Bloch theorizes, “[i]t may have been added by the author so that he could safely give vent to his heresy—which he succeeds in doing” (99). Another reading Bloch offers is that “it may be that the storm and nature scenes were interpolated later—which, in view of their poetic power and linguistic unity with what came before, is unlikely” (99). Since neither of these seem to attest to the power of the text, however, Bloch decides to take another strategy—eschewing the post-reformation strategies to harmonize the text in favor of some pietistic reading of reconciliation, Bloch recognizes in the “avenger” language of Job 19 a rejection of the present world order of indifference in favor of a messianic

hope that his suffering would be avenged. He states, “The sharp edge of Messianism is here in fact made manifest, in all the strength of its antithesis to the given world” and continues further that “[t]he answer to Job’s questioning, to his despair and hope for change, is given in terms of an Avenger, terms connected intimately with his own clear conscience, and in no other way” (101). Job repents in dust and ashes not because he sees a secret knowledge which explains his own impropriety but, rather, that in standing up for himself and taking himself to have been speaking the truth, he sees in the pietistic tradition a false account of the world as cosmic indifference and instead hopes for the contingency of a messiah: “The God who appears in Job... is a mere Pharaoh from heaven. Job is pious precisely because he does *not* believe” (107).

Our last commentator also recognizes the limit of theodicy as represented in the Book of Job. Immanuel Kant’s “On the Miscarriage of All Trials in Theodicy” provides a rationalist reading of the meaning of the Book of Job. Kant will make the case that the task of theodicy is to provide a juridical defense for a good, omnipotent God who is put on trial for the existence of evil. However, Kant will argue that the verdict of such a case cannot be resolved through the use of human faculties as the inherent limitation of our finitude leads us to simultaneously posit that our wills are free and also that our wills are determined by God—since we have no recourse to the reconcilability of this antinomy internal to reason, we have no ground to posit an understanding of the mechanism of providence. In this way, Kant reads the attempts of the friends as attempts to explain, through human faculties, the operation of the divine mind and, subsequently, reads the divine speeches at the end as a recognition of the incapacity for such a divine mind to communicate his ordinances to human understanding which is bounded by causality.

Kant identifies three forms of counterpurposiveness operative in the world; first, the absolutely counterpurposive (“what cannot be condoned or desired either as end or means”), second, the conditionally counterpurposive (“what can indeed never co-exist with the wisdom of a will as end, yet can do so as means”) and lastly, the counterpurposiveness corresponding to “the disproportion between crimes and penalties in the world” (25). It is on the basis of these three forms of counterpurposiveness that reason is driven to give a defense of “the highest wisdom of the creator” (24) in order to solidify its own confidence of the power of acting in the world. Respectively, the three attributes which correspond to these forms of counterpurposiveness are God’s *holiness* “as author of the world” and “*law-giver*”, its *goodness* “as *ruler*” regarding the community of rational minds, and lastly its *justice*, as regarding the distribution of crime of retribution.

Regarding God’s holiness, one may object that the absolutely counterpurposive, though unamenable to human ends and ways of thinking, are nevertheless acceptable according to God, but Kant quickly dismisses the absurdity of such a claim as a God who does not share our moral sentiments would not be one worthy of calling holy, as Kant states, “surely it can be freely given over to the detestation of every human being who has the least feeling for morality” (27). A second objection would be that God could be holy, but lack the power requisite to prevent such counterpurposiveness—however, such a vindication would remove the ground by which such a counterpurposiveness could be considered *absolute* and instead would have to be accepted as justified as a necessary feature of the world. Lastly, that God merely tolerates evil but in no way condones it—however Kant points out that such a defense would force us to accept the existence of evil as the inherent limitation in our power of acting and hence not something which human beings could avoid doing (and hence not something for which they could be held responsible).

Since this would undermine our freedom as rational agents, it would remove the ground by which we recognize moral evil and instead be a consequent feature of animality and not personhood.

Regarding God's goodness, one could attest that it is better to live than to die and hence that suffering must not be regarded as sufficient for encroaching on the goodness of God—however, as Kant states, “But surely the reply to this sophistry may be left to the sentence of every human being of sound mind who has lived and pondered over the value of life long enough to pass judgment, when asked, on whether he had any inclination to play the game of life once more” (28). Since annihilation is preferable to such a terrible fate, this theodicy is also absurd. Secondly, one could argue that pain and pleasure are both integral to the experience of the human animal and thus God could not create one without the other—however, if this were the defense, then one could immediately question as to motivations of a God who would create us at all. Kant's example here is helpful: “Ill humor would reply here as that Indian woman did to Genghis Khan, who could neither give her satisfaction for violence suffered nor afford security for the future: “If you will not protect us, why do you then conquer us?” (28). Lastly, one could appeal to the possibility of future happiness which would supercede our present sufferings—however such a defense, while *possible*, has no *necessary* ground and hence cannot serve as a theodicy.

Regarding God's justice, the first claim could be that unjust deeds go unpunished is false because the conscience of the depraved are the appropriate punishment for their crime. Kant objects to this by pointing out that it is more likely for the just to suffer from the conscience, while the depraved are wholly absent-minded regarding their own culpability for the counterpurposive in the world. Another objection could be that suffering only afflicts the

virtuous in order to perfect their virtue, but experience shows us that suffering is entirely contingent and often affects those who are already virtuous. The last theodicy according to Kant would be one which attempts to defend God's justice by arguing that justice for the virtuous will be secured at some future date but such an account, similar to the case with future happiness, cannot be regarded as a necessary ground and only as a possible ground.

Hence Kant concludes:

“Every previous theodicy has not performed what it promised, namely the vindication of the moral wisdom of the world-government against the doubts raised against it on the basis of what the experience of this world teaches—although, to be sure, as objections, so far as our reason's inherent insight regarding them goes, neither can these doubts prove the contrary” (30).

It is on the basis of this argument that Kant then turns to Job—recognizing in the three friends the various theodicies offered above, Kant states that Job is on the contrary dignified in his continued refusal of accepting his friend's answers. He states, “Job speaks as he thinks, and with the courage with which he, as well as every human being in his position, can well afford; his friends, on the contrary, speak as if they were being secretly listened to by the mighty one, over whose cause they are passing judgment” (32) and hence they necessarily misspeak when attempting to account for the operation of the divine mind in accordance with the categories of human understanding.

Kant then argues that this is confirmed by the divine speech stating, “For God deigned to lay before Job's eyes the wisdom of his creation, especially its inscrutability” allowing him a glimpse “into the beautiful side of creation” and also “the horrible side, by calling out to him the products of [God's] might” demonstrating “an order and a maintenance of the whole” which is necessarily inscrutable to us yet nevertheless hidden from our understanding (33). It is on this grounds therefore that “God finds against his friends, for (as conscientiousness goes) they have

not spoken as well as God as God's servant Job" who, though speaking *wantonly* nevertheless speaks honestly, if not unwisely. Hence Kant concludes that theodicy is not a matter of science, but rather of faith and hence, that Job—who was willing to be righteous despite not knowing the hidden art of God's providence, "proved that he did not found his morality on faith, but his faith on morality: in such a case, however weak this faith might be, yet it alone is of a pure and true kind" which is to say "the kind of faith that founds not a religion of supplication, but a religion of good life conduct" (33).

In conclusion, the common theme throughout these three commentators reading of the divine speeches is that they all agree, fundamentally, that the book of Job is a text about the human being's power of acting in the world. While we are given two atheistic accounts and one theistic accounts, they nevertheless all agree that the fundamental dignity in the human being is in its capacity to think rationally and, in using reason to set its own ends, to represent for itself the possibility of a better world. Such a possibility thus becomes the ground to critique all forms of suffering, though recognizing its inevitability, not on the basis of an impious rejection of life, but on the basis that the fundamental dignity of the human is undermined when suffering is justified through sophisticated means. Kant's account provides the framework on which the other two are built. For Kant, since the problem of theodicy is one internal to our reason—namely that we recognize that, as moral creatures, we are free agents, yet as creatures governed by divine providence, we are creatures determined by a will higher than our own. Nevertheless, Job, in recognizing the impossibility of all his friend's theodicies, does not undermine his own righteousness through explanation, but maintains in his honesty and good life-conduct throughout his trial. Similarly, the impossibility of there being a rational ground to suffering, which provides the ground for the legitimate critique of all suffering, is how Negri is able to

claim that there is no equivalence between forms of human suffering and hence why there can be no just remuneration for the labor which sustains the world. Furthermore, both Negri and Bloch agree that such labor should not be taken merely as meaningless suffering, but the ground on which a new creation is being birthed just as Kant, in recognizing the internal limitation of our own understanding, posits the view that the ground of our morally efficacious acts in the world is a matter of faith in a world-author whose supreme benevolence has providentially ordered the world such that it would be amenable to our moral conduct. Against sophistry, against justification, and against equivalence, the confidence of our power of acting in the world is secured to us by a belief in the inherent dignity of the human being and the hope that a world is coming which will one day secure it against that which is counterpurposive in the world.